

Brierley Investments Limited, and took out a number of advertisements in local newspapers promising “real adventure in the stock market.”¹⁰

R. A. Brierley Investments Limited is modeled on the successful techniques of the new overseas school of enterprising financiers—the takeover men—the merger experts—the “corporate raiders”. You’ve read the amazing stories of these millionaires. . . the same opportunities are here in New Zealand.

Now—even if you’ve never owned a share in your life—you can join in the secret and dramatic planned assaults on sleepy public companies. Mail the coupon below—today—for a free copy of the prospectus.

Those who did mail in the coupon received a thin, blue-bound document that set out the company’s objectives: It would “take over other companies and reorganize their finances, selling off surplus assets and reinvesting the funds for the more useful development of an existing business.”¹¹ It would also “invest in industries where mergers were inevitable.”¹² He offered newspaper quotes and analysis of the takeover technique employed by Charles Clore, a British financier. Though R. A. Brierley Investments had no earnings or assets, the capital raising was successful. In 1961, at 23, Brierley was running a public company with 200 shareholders holding 144,000 five-shilling shares for a total capitalization of about NZ£30,000 after costs (about \$1,000,000).

R. A. Brierley Investments’ first bid was for the Otago Farmers Co-operative Association of New Zealand Limited in July 1961.¹³ Otago Farmers had been moved to the unofficial list of the New Zealand Stock Exchange for failing to comply with official listing requirements. It was a typical Brierley target: an unusual legal structure, a slight taint provided by the removal from the official list, generating lackluster earnings, but with hidden and valuable assets. As he had with *Stocks and Shares*, Brierley personally folded and stuffed the offer documents, and licked each envelope. He hoped that the provocative bid would attract shareholders to R. A. Brierley Investments, but believed the chances of actually getting control of Otago Farmers were remote. He was right. The offer was not well received. Many of the shareholders returned the offer documents scrawled with obscenities in the reply-paid envelopes Brierley had included.¹⁴ The bid wasn’t a total loss, however. Shortly after Brierley’s offer, the company announced a change in its policy on shareholder discounts, and the market price of the stock leapt.¹⁵

Brierley launched his second bid for Southern Cross Building and Banking Society Limited in December 1961 for 20 shillings per share paid over three years.¹⁶ Like Otago Farmers, Southern Cross’s earnings were